

DREAMING BIG: At the Reliance refinery in Jamnagar

will keep his business model viable. While the issue of supplying gas to his brother's Reliance Energy is sorted out, he faces another political challenge in retail, his other big venture.

It is accepted economic logic that organised retail cuts costs, curbs wastage and creates jobs. The constituency of the unemployed poor farmers and consumers is unbeatable. Yet the traders who will be affected have mobilised political opposition in states like Uttar Pradesh, where Reliance Fresh shops were closed down as they were considered a law and order problem. Mukesh bristles at suggestions that it is the entry of the mega-corporation that has stirred political opposition.

Characteristically, he is undaunted by political opposition. "We have to work to change rigid and old mindsets," he asserts. Talk about ITC, which pioneered the concept of e-Chaupal, adopting a more co-optive method, and it elicits an amused look and a sharp retort: "We will learn from every experience and everyone's experience." Mukesh is convinced that organised retail will change the face of rural India and that Reliance will do it. "If you had asked me in 1997 what we would be known for, I would have said petrochemicals, in 2000 it would have been telecom, in 2005 energy security. Mark my words, by 2012, we would be known for rural transformation." To most entrepreneurs, handling one such mega project would be a lifetime's achievement. Mukesh is spearheading four complex initiatives—the SEZs at Jamnagar, Jhajhar and Mumbai, the 1,500-town retail rollout, the gas and exploration project and a second refinery at Jamnagar. Together, the investments in all these projects add up to over Rs 1,50,000 crore. It is this ability to multi-task that makes Mukesh a unique wealth creator. The question friends and competitors ask is how he manages it.

People think Reliance Industries is a one-man show. But that is not so. He works with a fully empowered team that works very hard. Mukesh lays out the overall plan, which is implemented by his core team that includes cousins Nikhil and Hetal Meswani, and Manoj Modi, supported by friend Anand Jain. The delegation of work affords him quality time with his family, whether it is teaching his son mathematics, helping his daughter with her SAT papers, or going for the weekly walk with wife Nita. And regular holidays are a must, say at Pebbles Beach in California, or the wildlife park in Botswana. What he has also eschewed consciously is the fluff from his social calendar. He will bunk an industry do or a global forum function to attend to his business and his family. But if it is N.K. Singh's book launch or a friend's 50th birthday halfway



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across town, he will take out time.

As news of his wealth grabs headlines, Mukesh faces questions. Unlike the Tatas, Reliance is not widely known for its philanthropy. You could say because Mukesh keeps his charity private, but also because he has again a radically different view. "I don't believe in mere lip service or cheque book philanthropy. Papa used to say self-respect is the biggest asset, particularly in the life of the poor." Mukesh believes India's biggest social and economic challenge is "how we grow the incomes of those living at the bottom of the pyramid." Finding the answer to this is critical to his future plans. Reliance currently generates cash reserves (profit after tax, plus depreciation) of Rs 30,000 crore a year. By 2009, this will be Rs 60,000 crore a year and by 2012, he would have over Rs 3,00,000 crore (including a portfolio of Rs 1,25,000 crore) to invest profitably. Through three decades, Reliance has bet on the India story. The biggest challenge facing growth now is not just inequality but abject poverty. So in a sense India's challenge is also a challenge for Reliance's growth. It has scale and requires changing the rules of the game. Who better than the man who has risen from the chawls of Bhuleshwar to be the richest in the world, to take the pot of gold closer to the poor. ■